PORTLAND PUBLIC SCHOOLS
Office of Internal Performance Audit
501 North Dixon Street / Portland, OR 97227
Telephone: (503) 916-2000
Mailing Address: P. O. Box 3107 / 97208-3107

Date: October 23, 2026

To: PPS Board of Education and Audit Committee Members

CC: Dr. Kimberlee Armstrong, Superintendent
Michelle Morrison, Chief Financial Officer
Sharon Toncray, Chief Legal Officer
Liz Large, Contracted General Counsel
Andrea Schiers, Senior Legal Counsel and legal liaison to the Audit Committee

From: Janise Hansen, Sr. Internal Performance Auditor (Internal Auditor)

Subject: Communications Protocol: Communications Between PPS Board of Education members, Audit Committee Members, and the Internal Auditor

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Purpose

Audit Standards recognizes the importance of direct and open communication between individual Board of Education (Board) members, Audit Committee (Committee) members, and the Internal Auditor. Such communication supports the independence and effectiveness of the internal audit function and enables the Board and Committee members to raise questions, concerns, potential audit matters, and other issues relevant to the Board's and Committee's oversight responsibilities.

These communications will be conducted in a manner consistent with Oregon Public Meetings Law, including requirements concerning serial communications.

Direct Communication with the Internal Auditor

Individual Board and Committee members may communicate directly with the Internal Auditor outside of a Board or Committee meeting. Such communications may include:

- Requesting or receiving factual or educational information;
- Asking questions regarding audit reports, audit plans, recommendations, or follow-up activities;
- Raising concerns regarding risk, internal controls, compliance, fraud, waste, abuse, or other matters relevant to the internal audit function;

- Suggesting matters for possible future audit consideration;
- Requesting clarification of information previously presented to the Committee; and
- Discussing administrative, scheduling, or other nonsubstantive matters.

Nothing in this protocol is intended to restrict an individual Board and/or Committee member's access to the Internal Auditor or the Internal Auditor's ability to communicate directly with individual Board and/or Committee members as appropriate to the Internal Auditor's responsibilities.

Avoidance of Serial Communications

The Internal Auditor, Board, and Committee members shall not use individual communications, whether directly or through an intermediary, that create deliberation or decision-making by a quorum of the Committee outside of a meeting conducted in accordance with Oregon Public Meetings Law.

Accordingly:

- The Internal Auditor should not communicate one Board and/or Committee member's substantive position on a matter to other Board and/or Committee members on topics that the Board and/or Committee will be deliberating.
- Board and/or Committee members should not ask the Internal Auditor to poll other Board and/or Committee members regarding their positions on a matter that is or may come before the Board and/or Committee; and the Internal Auditor should not share an understanding of Board and/or Committee member positions.
- The Internal Auditor should not serve as an intermediary through which Board and/or Committee members indirectly deliberate with one another.
- Email, text messages, telephone calls, individual meetings, or other communications should not be used in sequence that effectively creates deliberation among a quorum.

Information Gathering by the Internal Auditor

The Internal Auditor may communicate separately with individual Board and/or Committee members to obtain information, understand concerns, identify potential risks, prepare materials, or otherwise perform the responsibilities of the internal audit function.

When information obtained through individual communications relates to a matter that is likely to result in Board and/or Committee deliberation or action, substantive discussion among Board and/or Committee members should occur at a properly noticed Committee meeting.

Questions or Uncertainty

When there is uncertainty as to whether a proposed communication could constitute or contribute to prohibited serial communications, the Internal Auditor, Board, and/or Committee member should consult with District legal counsel, as appropriate, before proceeding.

This protocol is intended to facilitate effective communication between the Board and/or Committee members and Internal Auditor while ensuring that Board and/or Committee deliberations and decisions occur openly and in accordance with Oregon Public Meetings Law.
